‘responsible for carrying into execution the sentence of the law’ – why had he come to Akbar?

Perhaps Abdun Nabi was so used to the emperor’s esteem that he mistook his indecision for deference. The brahmin was killed. And Akbar was furious.

As Badauni tells it, the ‘ladies within and the Hindus without’ stirred the pot of Akbar’s fury, until the emperor summoned a meeting of scholars, jurists and divines around the great tank at Fatehpur, the Anup Talao. Badauni was amongst them, and was eventually ordered to speak. ‘When ninety and nine opinions are in favour of a sentence of death,’ Akbar asked him, ‘and a hundredth in favour of acquittal, do you think it right that the muftis should act upon the latter. What is your opinion?’

Badauni replied that the law advised against punishment ‘where there was any doubt’. He added, however, that Abdun Nabi may have had compelling reasons to act as he did. Did he do it, perhaps, ‘for the sake of expediency’?

If Badauni was trying to strike a balance that would offend nobody, he did not please Akbar. The emperor’s ‘hair stood on end’, writes Badauni, ‘like that of a roused lion’. People around him whispered for Badauni to shut up. Then, Akbar himself looked at him and said, ‘You are not at all right.’ Badauni bowed low and stepped back, silently vowing never to attend such meetings again.

Akbar’s fury did not have any immediate consequence on Abdun Nabi’s career. Perhaps the shaikh brushed it from his mind, telling himself that Akbar would soon find a conquest to distract him. But Akbar did not forget;[18] and if he thought of marching into new territory, it was that of his clergy.

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‘A general proclamation was issued,’ writes Abul Fazl, inviting the intelligentsia of Fatehpur, whether from scholarly circles or the common public, to descend upon the ‘delightful precincts’ of the Ibadat Khana every Thursday night, for debates that carried on till dawn. It was not always that Akbar sat at the centre, with his debaters in carefully demarcated spaces. In fact, Badauni describes Akbar going from group to group, listening and talking, giving money and lending books. It is a congenial scene, and